PICS II · CHALLENGE 7 · THEORY OF CHANGE

From Transit to Opportunity

Getting low-wage workers to jobs in India

How the **Access Line** policy turns activities into outputs, outcomes and lasting impact, and the assumptions, risks and indicators that test whether it will work.

THE PATHWAY OF CHANGE





Lead author: Harini V S
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Policy: The Access Line
Based on the Challenge 6 policy brief

This document shows how the Challenge 6 policy leads to real change. **Figure 1** is the Theory of Change. **Annex A** is the logframe. **Annex B** is the M&E framework.

IN SHORT *If cities track who can reach jobs, keep the daily commute under 10% of a day's wage, plan the whole trip from home to workplace, and link funding to results, then low-wage workers, especially women, can reach jobs within 45 minutes, safely and on time. More of them will take and keep jobs.*

01 The problem

Many low-wage workers cannot get to work on time, safely and cheaply. India built track fast, but not the trip to work: over 900 km of metro now runs in 20+ cities (cost above Rs 3.5 lakh crore), yet stations sit in housing belts while jobs move to highway edges.

25–35%

Wrong riders

Metros carry only 25–35% of forecast riders. Fares are too high for low-wage workers.

41% · 47%

Unplanned last mile

In Delhi the last mile takes 41% of commute time and 47% of the fare (ITDP India, 2026).

23×

Money follows track, not people

Rail got 23 times more than PM e-Bus Sewa in 2025–26.

No owner

No one owns the whole trip

Shift workers at the city edge are left out. Metro, city and utility agencies plan under separate mandates.

WHY THE GAP EXISTS

One-way rush

Peak trains run at up to 120% one way and 10–15% on the return, roughly an 80:20 split, so operators lose money on empty trips.

Jobs left the corridors

The 2017 National TOD Policy pushed housing near stations but did not require jobs there. Offices and factories moved to expressway edges.

Costly for the poor

About 82% of urban workers are informal, and low-income households can spend up to 28% of income on the commute (Challenge 6 brief).

Women are hit hardest

Share of each group in the workforce (MoSPI, 2026). Long, fragmented, poorly lit trips add a mobility cost that falls mostly on women.



02 The policy

Four levers, each aimed at one broken link in the trip to work. Existing bodies deliver them: city governments, the metropolitan transport authority, metro and bus agencies, development authorities, skill missions and employers. No new bureaucracy is created.

1 Measure

Publish a Jobs Access Score. Pick corridors and plan each journey from home to workplace. A joint team (transport authority, municipal commissioner, metro head) gives one clearance window for station plots within 45 days.

FIXES
No one owns the trip

2 Price

Monthly work pass shared by employer (40%), worker (30%) and government (30%). Shift-timed feeders and safe stops. Busy stations (15,000+ riders a day) get bus bays and electric shared-mobility docks.

FIXES
Wrong riders; last mile

3 Place

Job hubs at stations, within about 600 m. Extra building rights only if developers add affordable homes and floor space for jobs. About 15% of station forecourt space is kept for licensed vendors, kiosks and creches (Street Vendors Act, 2014).

FIXES
Last walk to work

4 Money

Grants tied to Score gains. Small employer payroll charge (0.3–0.5%). A share of developer premiums funds walking links and feeders. Central capital grants are linked to states giving the transport authority real powers.

FIXES
Money follows track

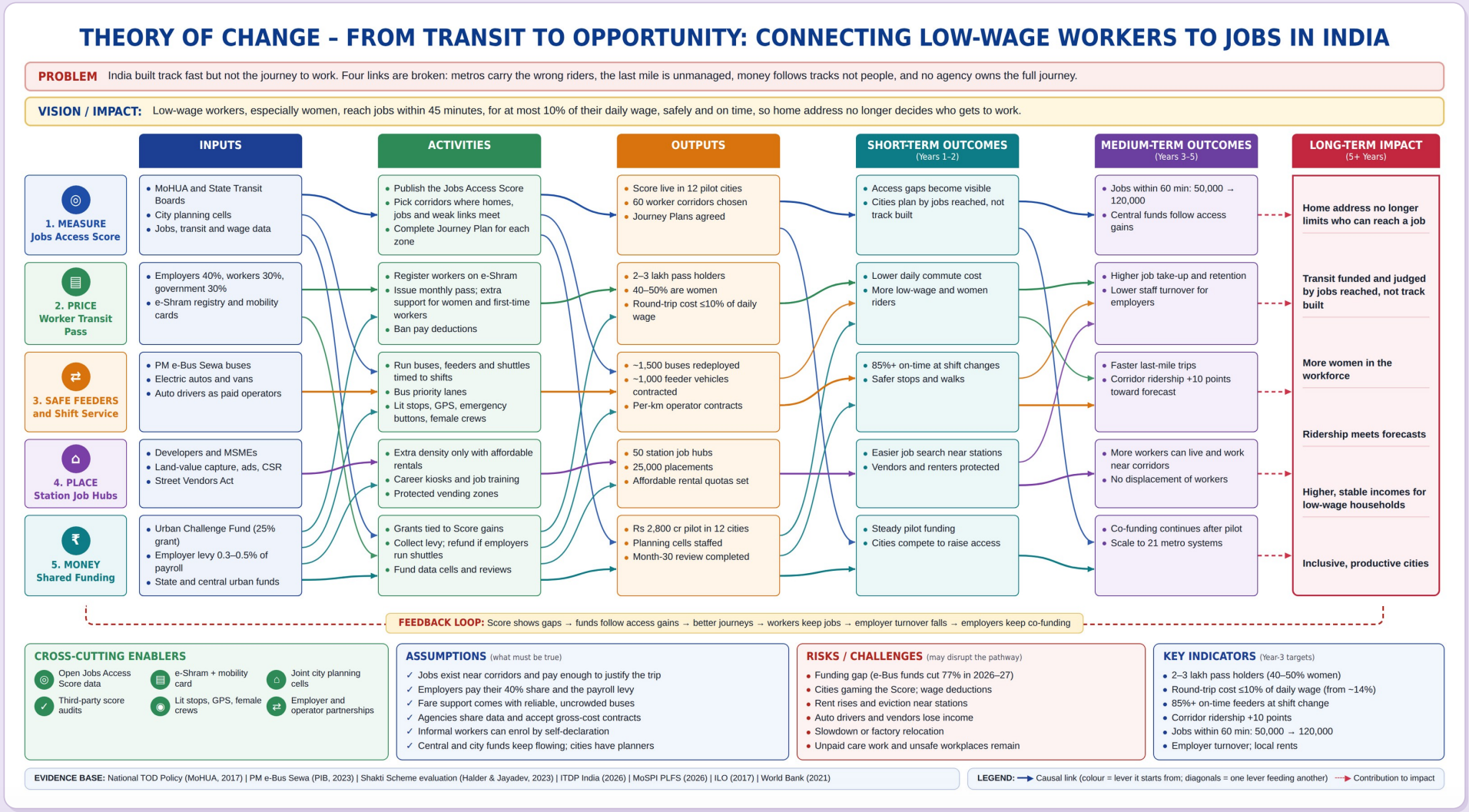
03 How change happens

Each stage sets up the next: cheaper, safer trips lead to daily commuting, then to jobs kept, then to a fairer city.

Activities START	Publish the Score. Issue passes. Run feeders. Open job hubs. Collect employer charge and grants. Give single-window clearances.	*Cheaper, safer trips timed to shifts*
Outputs YEAR 3	12 cities, 60 corridors. 2–3 lakh pass holders. About 1,500 buses, 1,000 feeders. 50 hubs, 25,000 placements. Safe walking links and vending zones at hub stations.	*Workers use them; cost, time and safety barriers fall*
Short-term outcomes YEARS 1–2	Shorter waits. Feeders 85% on time. Commute under 10% of daily wage. Safer stops and walks.	*Workers can make the trip every day*
Medium-term outcomes YEARS 3–5	More women and low-income riders. Jobs within 60 minutes: 50,000 to 120,000. Fewer staff leaving. More women in jobs. Trains and buses fill in both directions (peak split easing from about 80:20 toward 55:45).	*Workers take and keep jobs, and employers keep paying*
Long-term impact 5+ YEARS	Transit is judged by jobs reached. Home address no longer decides who can work. Poorer households keep more of their income, and station vendors and small firms share the gains.	*The change the policy exists for*

FIGURE 1

Theory of Change diagram



Line colour shows which lever a link starts from. Diagonal lines show one lever helping another.

04 What must be true

The assumptions the theory rests on. If one fails, the chain of change weakens.

1. **Jobs are near the corridors** and pay enough.
2. **Employers pay their share.**
3. **Buses stay reliable.** Cheap fares alone caused crowded, late buses in Karnataka (Halder & Jayadev, 2023).
4. **Transport agencies share data** and sign fair contracts.
5. **Informal workers can sign up.**
6. **Central and city money keeps coming.**
7. **Cities have enough planners.**
8. **One body can decide.** The transport authority gets real sign-off power, and rail, city and utility agencies accept one clearance window.
9. **Developers and employers will place jobs near stations** when the incentives are clear, even without a guaranteed anchor tenant.
10. **Walking links get fixed.** Footpaths, crossings and skywalks around hubs are built, or new jobs will only create bottlenecks.

Outside the policy's control: a slowdown in the wider economy, factories relocating, and central funding decisions. These are covered in the risks below.

05 Risks

Each risk is paired with the safeguard built into the policy.

RISK	SAFEGUARD
Funding falls short (PM e-Bus Sewa funds cut 77% in 2026–27)	Shared funding; review at month 30
Cities pick easy corridors	One national method; outside audits
Employers cut pay or hire only nearby	No pay deductions; labour audits
Rents rise near stations, pushing out small shops and low-income residents	Affordable rent quotas; anti-eviction rules; about 20% of new commercial space kept for small firms, non-profits and self-help groups at capped rent
Auto drivers and vendors lose income	Hire drivers as paid operators; protect vending zones with legal notification and digital registration cards (MoHUA, 2014)
Rail, city and utility agencies work in silos under conflicting mandates	State law gives the transport authority final sign-off in the station zone; central capital grants (PM GatiShakti) tied to it
Municipal bodies fear losing zoning control and revenue	Set share of value-capture and betterment levy goes straight to the city
Developers will not build offices without committed tenants	Tradable building rights and graded premiums; pre-signed employers at each hub
New jobs overload broken footpaths and crossings	A fixed share of development premiums (proposed 40%) is spent within 500 m on barrier-free walking links
Slowdown or factories move away	Review corridors every year
Unpaid care work; unsafe workplaces	Not solved here: the policy fixes transport only

06 Indicators of change

			NOW TO TARGET
		Now ○ Target	
Output	Pass holders		**0 → 2–3 lakh (40–50% women)**
Output	Corridors, buses, feeders, hubs		**0 → 60, ~1,500, ~1,000, 50**
Output	Priority walking links meeting safety and access standards		**Baseline audit → 90% (proposed)**
Output	Women in corridor planning and job services		**Baseline → 30% (proposed)**
Outcome	Commute cost as share of daily wage		**~14% → 10% or less**
Outcome	Feeders on time at shift change		**Baseline survey → 85% or more**
Outcome	Corridor ridership against forecast		**25–35% → +10 points**
Outcome	Peak-hour load split (busy direction : return)		**About 80:20 → 55:45 (proposed)**
Outcome	Staff leaving (employers)		Baseline survey; falling
Outcome	Jobs within 60 minutes		**50,000 → 120,000**
Impact	Women in jobs: pass holders against similar women without passes		Baseline; higher than the others
Impact	Cities using the Score to steer funds		**0 → 12 cities, then 21**
Watch	Rents; auto driver and vendor income		No sharp rise; no loss

Details are in Annex B. The goal is a 45-minute trip per worker; 60 minutes is the radius used to count jobs. Targets marked "proposed" come from the Challenge 6 brief and will be confirmed by baseline surveys.

07 Weakest points

TEST THIS FIRST

Employers

The plan needs them to pay 40%.

SHARED FUNDING

Funding

e-Bus money was cut. The pilot must work on shared funding.

COMPARISON GROUP

Proof

Women's work changes for many reasons, so compare pass holders with similar workers without passes.

GOVERNANCE

Authority

The transport authority needs real sign-off power. Without it, silos between agencies slow every hub.

Sources

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ANNEX A

Logical Framework (Logframe)

LOGICAL FRAMEWORK (LOGFRAME): FROM TRANSIT TO OPPORTUNITY

The Access Line (Employment-Oriented Transit Zones) | Pilot in 12 Indian cities | Framework horizon 2026–2031

Objectives	Measurable indicators	Means of verification	Important assumptions
GOAL *Wider problem the policy will help to resolve* Low-wage workers, especially women, can reach jobs wherever they live, and transit is planned and funded around jobs reached, not track built.	• Jobs reachable within 60 min on pilot corridors: 50,000 → 120,000 • Women's employment among pass holders, compared with similar workers on non-pilot routes: rising • Corridor ridership moves toward forecasts (25–35% carried today) • Jobs Access Score used to steer central transit funds: 12 pilot cities → 21 metro systems	• Published Jobs Access Score (third-party audited) • Follow-up survey of a pass-holder panel and comparison group • Operator ridership data • Grant and funding-rule records (MoHUA, State Transit Boards)	***(Goal to supergoal)*** • The economy keeps creating jobs near the corridors • Centre and States keep grant conditions linked to the Score • Unpaid care work and unsafe workplaces do not block women: transit removes only the travel barrier
PURPOSE *Immediate change for the target group* Low-wage workers in pilot cities reach jobs within 45 minutes, for at most 10% of their daily wage, on safe transport timed to their shifts.	• Round-trip cost as share of daily wage: about 14% (Delhi baseline) → 10% or less • Feeder runs on time at shift changes: 85% or higher • Pass holders reaching work within 45 min and feeling safe on stops and walks: target set after baseline survey • Corridor ridership: +10 percentage points toward forecast (Year 3) • Employer staff turnover: falling from 16.2% (India avg, Aon)	• Pass, fare and worker survey data • GPS tracking of buses and feeders • Commuter survey (door-to-job time, safety) • Operator ridership data • Employer survey	***(Purpose to goal)*** • Jobs exist near the corridors and pay enough to justify the trip • Cheaper, faster travel leads workers to take and keep jobs (wages, family duties and safety also matter) • Employers see lower turnover and keep co-funding
OUTPUTS *Specific results delivered by Year 3*			***(Outputs to purpose)*** • Fare support is matched by reliable, uncrowded buses • Informal workers can enrol by self-declaration • Employers do not deduct pass costs from pay or hire only nearby workers • Auto drivers and vendors stay in (paid operators, vending zones) • Rents near stations do not push workers out
O1 Measure: Jobs Access Score published, corridors chosen and Journey Plans agreed	Score live in 12 cities (by month 18); 60 worker corridors (6 per city); a Journey Plan for each zone	Published Score reports; city corridor lists; audit reports	
O2 Price: Worker Transit Pass in use	2–3 lakh pass holders, 40–50% women	Pass system and e-Shram records	
O3 Feeders: Safe, shift-timed service running	~1,500 buses redeployed; ~1,000 feeder vehicles contracted; lit stops with GPS and alerts	Contract and fleet records; GPS logs; stop audits	
O4 Place: Station job hubs open	50 hubs; 25,000 placements; affordable rental quotas set	Hub and placement registers; development approvals	
O5 Money: Shared funding in place	Rs 2,800 cr pilot committed; planning cells staffed; month-30 review done	Grant agreements; budget records; review report	
ACTIVITIES *Tasks to produce the outputs, with inputs (3-year pilot budget)*			***(Activity to output)*** • Central and state funds arrive on time (PM e-Bus Sewa funds were cut 77% in 2026–27) • Employers agree to pay their 40% share and the payroll charge • Transport agencies open route data and accept gross-cost contracts • Cities have enough planners and data staff
A1 Measure: Publish the Score, choose corridors, write Journey Plans, set up joint planning cells	**Inputs:** Data cells and reviews, about Rs 420 cr (15%), from shared central and state urban funds	Financial out-turn report; planning cell records	
A2 Price: Register workers on e-Shram; issue the monthly pass (employer 40%, worker 30%, government 30%); extra support for women and first-time workers	**Inputs:** Pass discounts, about Rs 980 cr (35%), from Urban Challenge Fund grants	Financial out-turn report; e-Shram registrations	
A3 Feeders: Contract electric feeders and shuttles; redeploy PM e-Bus Sewa buses; hire auto drivers as operators; build bus lanes and lit stops	**Inputs:** Feeder fleets and stops, about Rs 840 cr (30%), from PM e-Bus Sewa and state funds	Signed contracts; per-km payment records	
A4 Place: Give extra density for affordable rentals; open career kiosks and training; protect vending zones	**Inputs:** Station job hubs, about Rs 560 cr (20%), from land-value capture, ads and CSR	Development approvals; hub records	
A5 Money: Release grants tied to Score gains; collect the employer payroll charge (0.3–0.5%, refunded if shuttles run)	**Inputs:** Total Rs 2,800 cr: public Rs 2,000 cr, employers Rs 800 cr	Grant release records; levy collection and refund records	

Source: Challenge 6 policy brief (From Transit to Opportunity). Rupee splits for A1–A4 apply the brief's component shares (35/30/20/15%) to the Rs 2,800 cr pilot and are author estimates. Baselines: ITDP India (2026); MoSPI (2026).

ANNEX B

Monitoring and Evaluation Framework

	GOAL 1	GOAL 2	GOAL 3
INDICATOR	**Jobs reachable within 60 minutes of low-income settlements on pilot corridors**	**Women's job take-up and retention among pass holders and first-time workers**	**Central transit funds steered by the Jobs Access Score**
DEFINITION How is it calculated?	Number of jobs that can be reached within 60 minutes by transit from low-income settlements, worked out with the Jobs Access Score method	Women in the panel who are in paid work 12 months after enrolling, divided by all women in the panel, multiplied by 100. Compared with similar women on routes without the pass	Number of pilot cities and metro systems whose central transit grants depend on Score gains
BASELINE What is the current value?	50,000	Measured at baseline (context: urban women's participation is 24.8%, MoSPI 2026)	0
TARGET What is the target value?	120,000 by Year 5	Higher than the comparison group; number fixed after baseline	12 pilot cities, then 21 metro systems
DATA SOURCE How will it be measured?	Jobs Access Score (jobs data, timetables, settlement maps)	Panel survey of pass holders and a comparison group	MoHUA grant and funding-rule records
FREQUENCY How often will it be measured?	Annual	Annual	Annual
RESPONSIBLE Who will measure it?	City planning cells, with third-party audit	Independent evaluator	MoHUA
REPORTING Where will it be reported?	Published Jobs Access Score report	Annual evaluation report and final evaluation	Annual funding report

	OUTCOME 1	OUTCOME 2	OUTCOME 3	OUTCOME 4
INDICATOR	**Round-trip commute cost as a share of daily wage**	**On-time feeder runs at shift changes**	**Corridor ridership against forecast**	**Employer staff turnover**
DEFINITION How is it calculated?	Average daily round-trip fare (pass share plus feeder fare) divided by daily wage, multiplied by 100, for surveyed pass holders	Feeder runs that arrive within the agreed time window at shift changes, divided by all scheduled shift-change runs, multiplied by 100	Average daily riders on pilot corridors divided by forecast riders, multiplied by 100; change shown in percentage points	Workers who left in the year divided by average workforce, multiplied by 100, for partner employers
BASELINE What is the current value?	About 14% (Delhi, ITDP India 2026); re-measured in each city	Measured at baseline	Typical lines carry 25–35% of forecast; city figure measured at baseline	India average 16.2% (Aon, 2025); frontline-heavy sectors 25–35%; partner firms' records at enrolment
TARGET What is the target value?	10% or less by Year 3	85% or higher	+10 percentage points toward forecast by Year 3	Falling against baseline; number fixed after baseline
DATA SOURCE How will it be measured?	Pass and fare data; worker survey	GPS tracking of feeders and buses	Operator ticketing and mobility card records	Employer records and employer survey
FREQUENCY How often will it be measured?	Every 6 months	Monthly	Quarterly	Annual
RESPONSIBLE Who will measure it?	City data cells	Operators, checked by city data cells	Transit operators, checked by city data cells	Employers, collected by city planning cells
REPORTING Where will it be reported?	6-monthly pilot dashboard	Monthly operator report; quarterly review	Quarterly ridership report	Annual employer survey report

Goal and outcome indicators.

ANNEX B (CONTINUED)

Monitoring and Evaluation Framework

	OUTPUT 1	OUTPUT 2	OUTPUT 3	OUTPUT 4	OUTPUT 5
INDICATOR	**Jobs Access Score published and corridors planned**	**Worker Transit Pass holders**	**Buses redeployed and feeders contracted**	**Station job hubs and placements**	**Pilot funding committed and reviewed**
DEFINITION How is it calculated?	Number of pilot cities publishing the Score with the national method, and number of corridors with an agreed Journey Plan	Number of workers with an active monthly pass; women's share is women pass holders divided by all pass holders, multiplied by 100	Number of buses moved to worker corridors and feeder vehicles under contract and running to schedule	Number of hubs open, and number of workers placed in jobs through the hubs	Amount of pilot funding committed and released against the Rs 2,800 cr plan, and whether the month-30 review is complete
BASELINE What is the current value?	0	0	0	0	0
TARGET What is the target value?	12 cities (by month 18); 60 corridors (6 per city)	2–3 lakh pass holders; 40–50% women (Year 3)	~1,500 buses; ~1,000 feeder vehicles (Year 3)	50 hubs; 25,000 placements (Year 3)	Rs 2,800 cr committed; review done by month 30
DATA SOURCE How will it be measured?	Published Score reports; city corridor lists; audit reports	Pass system and e-Shram records	Contract and fleet records; GPS logs	Hub records and placement register	Grant agreements; financial out-turn reports
FREQUENCY How often will it be measured?	Every 6 months	Monthly	Quarterly	Quarterly	Quarterly
RESPONSIBLE Who will measure it?	City planning cells; third-party auditor	Transit agency (pass administrator)	Transport corporations, checked by city data cells	Hub managers	MoHUA and State Transit Board finance cells
REPORTING Where will it be reported?	Public Jobs Access Score report	Monthly pilot dashboard	Quarterly progress report	Quarterly hub report	Financial out-turn report; month-30 review report

Evaluation points and safeguards

- **Months 0 to 6:** baseline surveys in every pilot city fix the baselines marked "measured at baseline" (the Score goes live at month 6).
- **Month 30 review:** check outputs and outcomes against targets and decide whether to scale nationally from month 36.
- **End of Year 5:** final evaluation compares pass holders with similar workers on non-pilot routes, so changes can be linked to the policy and not only to the wider economy.
- **Watch alongside:** last-mile travel time, low-income ridership, local rents, and incomes of auto drivers and vendors, to catch harm such as displacement early.

Sources: Challenge 6 policy brief, Theory of Change and logframe. Baselines from ITDP India (2026) and a 2023 ridership study; other figures as given in the brief.

Output indicators and evaluation points.